Life is So Good

By George Dawson and Richard Glaubman

INTRODUCTION

People spend most of their lives in the quest of happiness and can't find it. See, the problem is they look to the world to provide them with reasons to be happy. But according to Ralph Marston, "Happiness is a choice, not a result. Nothing will make you happy until you choose to be happy."

In this selection, George Dawson, a 101-year-old black man who didn't learn to read until he was 98, recalls a childhood event that set his course through life – the death of Pete, an older boy who was George's hero.

George's father helped his son deal with Pete's death and also taught him a lesson that stuck with George for over a hundred years: Despite all the negative forces at work in our society . . .

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Pg 3-13

Wanting to enjoy every moment, I stared at the hard candies in the different wooden barrels. The man behind the counter was white. I could tell he didn't like me, so I let him see the penny in my hand.

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"Take your time, son. You did a man's work this year. Putting his hand on my shoulder, he said to the store clerk, "He's all of ten years, but the boy crushed as much cane as I did."

Since the age of four, I had always been working to help the family. I don't know if it was pride from Father's words or the pleasure from a piece of hard candy that beckoned, but I felt so good I thought I would burst. I had been thinking of those hard candies since my father woke me before daybreak and said, "Hitch the wagon. We gonna take some ribbon syrup into town and you comin'."

I wanted to tell him that I was glad he was taking me and it was going to be just him and me together all day. He took care of us. We had potatoes and carrots buried in the straw and salt pork hangin' from the rafters. We was free of worries. Papa was a good provider. Someday I would be just like him.

"With this ribbon syrup, we be out of debt and have some left for trading. We gonna have

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seeds for cotton, some new banty chicks, and the fruit trees that are gonna bear fruit next year. No one has the fever and we all be healthy. Life is good." And with a grin, he added, " I do believe it's getting better." I liked it when Papa talked to me as a man.

It was 1908, and I hadn't yet seen a car. I had heard of them, but nobody I knew owned one. The cafe and the barbershop was whites only, but I knew a boy that worked in the cafe. And I knew some folks that shined shoes at the barbershop.

I remember everything. I saw the white man frowning, my father grinning at me, and those barrels of candy to choose from. I also remember everything my ears told me that day. As I picked up a piece of peppermint, I heard a commotion from the street. My father's gaze followed mine. There were people running, harsh words, and a lot of shouting. Papa run to the door. I followed with the counterman behind me. I heard Pete's voice before I saw him. "It wasn't me. I didn't touch

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her," Pete screamed. "Lord, let me go.

First time in my life I saw the white folks and the colored folks together in a crowd. It scared me. There was no more frown on the face of the white counterman that was beside of me. His lips were set in a smile. Hate was in his eyes. Across the street, in front of the barbershop, I saw three colored men frozen in place. The white folks surrounding them had red, twisted faces. They were screaming. I had done nothing, but I felt them screaming at me.

"Kill the nigger boy, kill the nigger. They can't be messing with our white women."

Six men had Pete by the arms. The toes of his boots dragged in the dust. His face looked up to the sky as he screamed, "I didn't touch her."

I knew Pete and knew that was so. I shouted, "Pete, I'll tell-" My father's hand clamped over my mouth. His other arm crushed the air right out of my chest. I read his eyes and then he slowly let me go without saying a word. I

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knew it wasn't so, though. The Rileys' cook had heard the whole thing; she just kept on working in the kitchen and watched Betty Jo and her father. Betty Jo had gotten herself in trouble. When her daddy found out she was with a child, she had a whipping coming sure enough. Her daddy was steaming mad and of short temper anyhow.

"Who's the boy that done this to you?" her daddy shouted. Betty Jo looked at the belt in his hand. She was crying but wouldn't say nothing. She was scared, and afraid to tell the boy's name, because she figured that her daddy just might go off and kill him. "Well, if you did this 'cause you wanted to, a good beating will teach you right. You got it coming unless maybe this happened against your will. Is that what happened?" he said slowly.

Scared as she was, Betty Jo could tell that the safe answer was yes. Not wanting to tell a whole lie, she just nodded her head.

"Damn. Was it that Jackson boy from across the ridge?"

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Betty Jo, she loved him, or at least thought she did, shook her head no. Her daddy looked at her hard. His face turned angry and he said, "Was it our hired boy, Pete? That worthless, lazy nigger! Did he rape you? Did he do this?" To each question, she just nodded in the smallest way. The tears still flowed, but he threw the belt down and stormed out the door.

Pete was seventeen and the hired boy around their farm-picking cotton, cutting cane, chores like that. He was a good worker. But he was smart and he knew enough not to even look at a white woman. I knew Pete since we were little. Pete, he would do anything for anybody. As I was growing up, I didn't have any toys, but I did still own a baseball that Pete had given me a year earlier. Pete played shortstop. He was good too. If you wanted fast, you should have seen Pete run the bases. Pete was my hero. The colored couldn't play in the big leagues, but if they could I know Pete would of made it.

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Yeah, someone had committed a sin and Pete was gonna pay for it. I looked down the boardwalk. They was dragging Pete in the direction of the post office. Sheriff Tate stepped off the boardwalk up ahead from where the mob was. I let out a big breath of air. The sheriff was a big man. I knew he could stop this. People was spilling off the boardwalk and cursing Pete something terrible.

"We gonna keep our women safe."

"Make that boy pay and show all the niggers that they can't get away with this."

Pete was kicking and thrashing, but the mob was still hauling him farther down the street. Taking a few steps along the edge of the road, the sheriff stopped. A big pistol hung off his belt. He pulled the pistol out and crossed his arms so that the pistol set against his chest. He turned and looked back toward the boardwalk. The sheriff was in front of a group of colored that was pressed into the crowd. He scowled and sent

4N6 Fanatics

them a message that gave me a chill on a hot day. I had heard tell that the sheriff ran with the Klan at night when they would come through the colored section or out to the colored farms. They would leave a burning cross or shoot some windows out. That's what people said about him and now I knew it was true.

Behind us, a man was pushing his way out of the store. The sheriff walked toward us and waved his pistol. We opened up some space and let the man through. I saw the big coil of rope slung over his shoulder. I wanted to cry, but I held it back. He ran along the edge of the street and a couple other men stepped down to join him. Some of them were farmers I recognized from when we delivered our cotton. They looked like ordinary farmers with overalls and farm work boots. But that day, their hateful faces made them different. As they caught up alongside Pete, the mob seemed to get inspired. Pete had been twisting and screaming all get-out, but those men

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seemed to double their strength when they seen the lynching rope coming.

Someone pulled a wagon into the shade under the rope. Pete was closer now, could see the rope and the wagon. His shouts and protests had changed to cries for mercy. "I swear to God it wasn't me. Have mercy, you've got the wrong man. I didn't touch her."

Pete's eyes had a wild look as more men began milling around him. He was up on his feet now, but it was more that they was holding him up. Pete was swaying, as if he was about to faint. His face was all bloodied, but his eyes could see clear what was going to happen. His arms were pinned behind him and someone had bound him around the wrists. One of the men in the buckboard said, "Get that boy up here." Now it was Pete that stood steady and still.

Some men were still holding Pete tight from behind so that he couldn't even budge. But if Pete knew he was gonna die, the fear had left his face.

4NG Fanatics

[Then] Pete's legs buckled. He moaned as those men dragged him the remaining few feet around to the back of the buckboard.

"I didn't do nothing," Pete cried in a voice that rang without hope. I buried my head against my father's chest.

When I heard the whip snap and the buckboard lurch forward, I looked back. Pete's neck broke instantly; his head rested at an awkward angle. His eyes were open and he looked out at everyone. As he swayed from the tree, the crowd hushed and tried to look away from his accusing eyes. Not till Pete's body stopped swinging did anyone move. The crowd broke up in silence and went their separate ways.

I didn't want to, but as we left Marshall I turned 'round in my seat and looked. Pete was still looking at me and I knew that he always would be. Pete would stay till morning. When they did a lynching, they made us leave the body hanging, to put a terror in the colored folk.

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His face looked different than I had ever seen it, but Papa still hadn't said a word.

"I will never work for or talk to a white person again." I said with anger.

My father, who had seemed lost in his own thoughts, jerked his head and looked at me. "That was wrong what they did. Those white folks are mean and nasty people." Papa swallowed hard and pulled up on the reins so that the wagon stopped. He turned toward me. "No. You will work for white folks. You will talk to them."

"But, Papa, what about Pete? He didn't do

"Yeah, I know they had no cause for that, but- his suffering is over, son. It's all over for Pete. You don't need to worry for him."

"Some of those white folks was mean and nasty. Some were just scared. It doesn't matter. You have no right to judge another human being. Don't you ever forget."

My father had spoken. There was nothing to say. I didn't know it then, but his words set the

4NG Fanatics

direction my life would take even till this day. I cried and my daddy wrapped his arms around me and held me to his chest. Then something broke loose deep inside. I didn't know a body could have so many tears. I cried for me. I cried for Pete. I cried for the little ones and for Mama and Papa. I cried for all the pain that there was in this world. Papa had his own tears and he just held me. When the tears slowed, Papa told me. "This morning, I said that you did a man's work. But you was still a boy. Now you are learning to be a man."

About six months after the lynching, Betty Jo had her baby. It was a boy, a little white boy. No one said nothing. I guess by then most folks, white folks anyway, had all forgotten. I didn't forget.

I'm one hundred and one years old now. But I still remember. Though that was over ninety years ago, I see it in my mind like I was there today. I can't let loose of my memories, even if I

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wanted to. Yeah, I've seen it all in these hundred years, the good and the bad.

(PG 260) Things will be alright. Most folks just don't understand. Life is so good and it gets better every day.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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